MOUNTAIN REVIEW

OFFICIAL NEWSLETTER OF THE MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

Volume XI Issue III Summer 2021



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A Historical Reunion!

Summer Ice Cream Social



Our Summer 2021 Event

We are so excited to invite our members to our first in-person event since March of 2020! Join us on the afternoon of Sunday, August 1 at the Rengstorff Park group picnic area for a fun and informal gathering in the beautiful Mountain View summer sunshine. To sweeten the joy of reuniting, we'll have free It's-It ice cream sandwiches for everyone who RSVPs.

We'll also have a display of recently donated historical items for folks to view, giveaways of a few surplus items from the archives, lawn games to play, and Mountain View historical books for sale. Please visit our eventbrite page to RSVP and receive detailed directions to the picnic area we reserved. We kindly request RSVPs by July 28 to ensure we have enough It's-Its to go around. We hope to see you there!

Above: This image shows Rengstorff Park's picnic area—the location of our summer event—under construction. The historic Castro family estate, Villa Francisca, is visible in the background.

RSVP at:

http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com

Sunday, August 1, 2021 ● 3:00 p.m. to 5:00 p.m. ● Rengstorff Park, Mtn. View

MOUNTAIN REVIEW

This newsletter is published four times a year by the
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

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News & Notes

President's Message

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President


Pamela Baird

What's behind us and what's next? As the city, the county, and the country start to emerge from the pandemic one can't help but wonder—what's next?

As we look forward, it's also easy to look back as well. When the pandemic first started to spread rapidly, so much was unknown about the disease and how it spread. Could you get it from touching a surface? Put on gloves and wash your hands repeatedly. Does it spread through the air? Wear a mask. What kind of distance should I keep from people? Six feet or better yet, stay home, and don't go anywhere.

Several weeks into the pandemic I awoke at 2 a.m. with a panic attack, which I had never experienced before (and thankfully haven't since). My husband and I talked about having a feeling of impending doom. He described it as the same feeling he sometimes felt when serving in the rural jungles of Vietnam.

A few months ago the MVHA received a copy of the 1919 Mountain View Union High School yearbook. There is a paragraph in the yearbook that states "The terrible wave of Spanish influenza, which swept the country recently, closed our school for all but five weeks of our first semester. This put us far behind in our school work and, in fact, in all of our activities. Everyone came back to school on the 6th of January, however, inspired with the determination to make up the time lost. Since then the school has been pervaded with a feeling of business-like activity lacking in other years. We have been able to make up for time lost, thanks to our teachers' earnest endeavors and our own hard work."

While still being careful, many of us are experiencing the need to make up for lost time, just like those students over one hundred years ago. Meals with friends and family, meeting with others outside your "bubble," and traveling, both near and far, have been experienced with a profound new appreciation.

There is still much to be determined ahead. How or when will people go back to the workplace? What lifestyle adjustments will be made in the near future and further out? How will people conduct business and civic activities? Will a hybrid model of meetings be adopted? There are many advantages of conducting meetings in a virtual format. It will take much time for things to be sorted out and the best practices recognized. Like many organizations, MVHA will be trying to determine the best ways to engage our Board members and to conduct fun and interesting general meetings for our members.

Our first "in-person" general membership meeting will be Sunday, August 1. The Board is excited to host a chance for our members to get together in person for the first time in almost 18 months. It's a beginning step as we work to determine the best ways for us to gather and learn more about the past and present. See you soon!

—Pamela

MVHA Board Updates

By Nicholas Perry
MVHA Past President

Your MVHA Board of Directors is working on a wide range of exciting projects many of which were discussed at a jam-packed Board of Directors Meeting on June 9. A few highlights below:

Los Altos History Museum Exhibit Update: Our friends at the Los Altos History Museum (LAHM) reached out to the MVHA for our input on adding more elements of Mountain View history to their permanent exhibit, which is currently being redesigned. Elisabeth Ward, the LAHM's Executive Director, came to our June 9 board meeting and shared an update on their permanent exhibit redesign project. The LAHM understands that the histories of Mountain View and Los Altos our closely intertwined, and with many Mountain View schoolchildren visiting the museum, the LAHM is making a concerted effort to ensure Los Altos's history is framed in a broader regional context that includes Mountain View. The MVHA Board formed a subcommittee to offer suggestions on places and individuals to highlight in the LAHM exhibit. We'll keep you updated as this exciting collaboration progresses!

Color of Law Event: Our board also welcomed Michael Kahan, co-director of the Program on Urban Studies at Stanford University, to our June board meeting. Mr. Kahan is a Mountain View resident (and new MVHA member!) who is studying the historical impacts of racism on local housing. His research is inspired by *The Color of Law*, a book by Richard Rothstein that illuminates the impacts of government policies on housing segregation across America. The Mountain View Human Relations Commission recently voted to partner with Mr. Kahan on an event that will serve as an opportunity for the community to understand, share, and discuss the local impacts of this difficult aspect of American history. At Mr. Kahan's invitation, the MVHA Board also agreed to partner on this event and a subcommittee was formed to assist with research and planning.

Interpretive Signage: We continue to collaborate with the City of Mountain View on researching content for new interpretive signage at historic sites in the city. As reported in previous newsletters, we are currently working on signage content for an interpretive sign at the new Wynadotte Park. We were also recently approached by the City of Mountain View to help develop a historic marker for the location of Mountain View's historic Chinatown near Villa and View streets in Downtown Mountain View.

These are just a few of the projects our Board is pursuing. Suffice to say, we have more projects and ideas than we have volunteers. So if you're interested in getting involved, please don't hesitate to reach out to any one of your friendly MVHA Board members. We can be reached at info@mountainviewhistorical.org



Harvest Festival Returns!

By Marina Marinovich
MVHA Publicity Committee Chair

Before there was tech, there were orchards. Silicon Valley was known as The Valley of Heart's Delight, and Mountain View is nestled serenely at its center. Come to the 3rd annual Mountain View Harvest History Festival and celebrate our valley's rich and fertile past. Heritage Park is home to this family-friendly event on Saturday September 18, 9:00 a.m. to noon. Tour the gardens, sample harvest bounty, and enjoy children's activities and art projects, live music, and bubble entertainment. View the historic Immigrant House, and see garden demonstrations. Bike or walk in. For more information about this FREE event, contact Mountain View Parks and Recreation at (650) 903-6331.

Financial Report

By Emily Ramos
MVHA Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 3/31/2021: $21,257.45 Income: $2,234.75
Expenses: $785.79
Checking Account Balance as of 7/3/2021: $22,706.50

Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 3/31/2021: $60,519.62
Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 7/3/2021: $60,519.62

Mtn. View Memories

A Dutchman Remembers Mid-Century Mtn. View



The Sears store on San Antonio Road in Mountain View opened in 1957.

By Robert Cox
MVHA Vice President

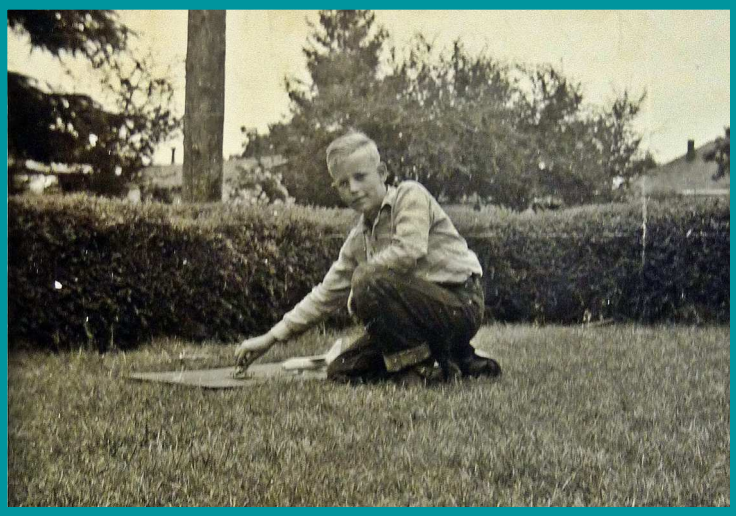
A few months ago, MVHA received a letter from a gentleman in Holland named Arthur Graaff. Mr. Graff was a young man in the 1950s. His father had worked for the Dutch resistance during World War II, and sadly, was captured by the Nazis, spending three years in a prison camp. After the war, Mr. Graaff's father took his family to California, where they lived in several different locations, the last of which was Mountain View.

Although the Graaffs were in Mountain View for only a brief time, Arthur commented, "Mountain View was my last love in the US. We were simply happy there. I even fell in love with a Mexican American classmate!"

Arthur recalled spending hours at the Sears store near El Camino Real, and a visit to a special location near that Sears store:

"One day, it must have been spring or summer of 1958, my father at dinner mentioned that a man had received a special award, the Nobel Prize. William Shockley was, of course, the man. Being a curious 11-year-old boy, strongly stimulated by the relatively free and easy-going way of life in California then, one day I took my bike (a black Raleigh medium size with three speeds, that I would never have received if we would have stayed in war-torn Holland) and decided to go and pay Shockley a visit to see what he was doing.

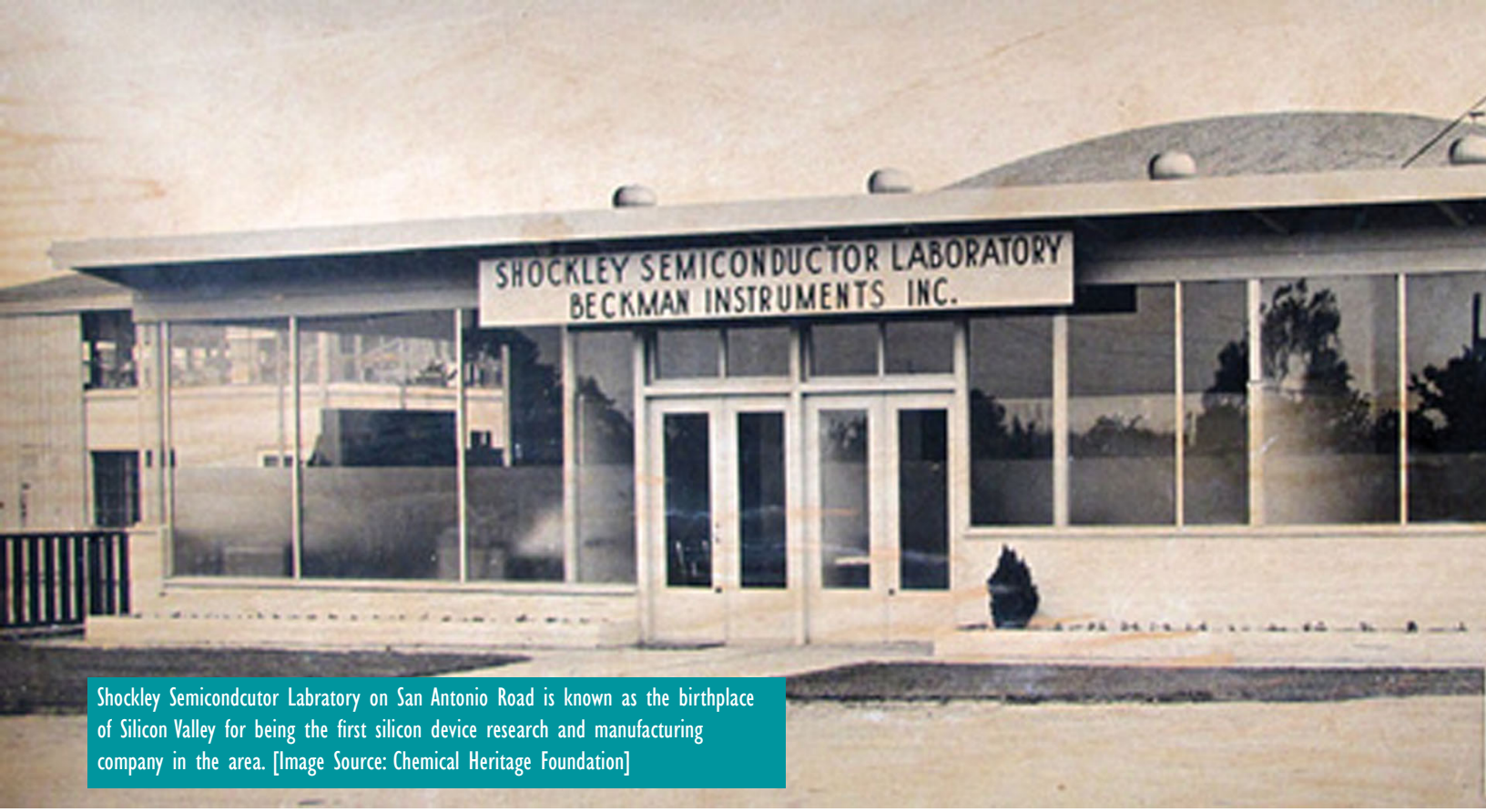
Continued on page 5



Arthur Graaff at the age of 10 at his childhood home at 1577 Latham Street in Mountain View.



Arthur's father, Bart Graaff, at 1577 Latham Street in Mountain View.



Shockley Semicondcutor Labratory on San Antonio Road is known as the birthplace of Silicon Valley for being the first silicon device research and manufacturing company in the area. [Image Source: Chemical Heritage Foundation]

Continued from page 4

Without any difficulty I found the lab, stepped up to the door without any hesitation, rang the bell, and the door was opened by the great man himself. He was a bit surprised but invited me in where I saw a handful of younger men in white coats busy with things unnamable, but technical and refined. I do not remember one word of what Shockley said to me, nor the reaction of my parents when I told them I had been there. The lab was to my recollection just an ordinary family dwelling like ours, with maybe the garage attached to it as an annex."

I mentioned to Mr. Graaff while our San Antonio shopping center is much changed, the spirit of innovation in Mountain View lives on. While Shockley's legacy was later tarnished by his views on race, and the old lab is gone, I let Mr. Graff know a pair of monuments to the birth of Silicon Valley now stand on the site. We also corresponded about the new spirit of cooperation between the US and our traditional European allies, renewing the partnership we had at the time of World War II. All in all, I am glad to know our city is remembered so warmly after so many years.



A recent image of Arthur Graaff appearing on Al-Jazeera Television in September 2019. Mr Graaff is now a journalist, a publisher, and an active anti-fascist in the Netherlands.

MTN. VIEW Memories

Mountain View Memories is a recurring special feature of our newsletter where we publish memories of times gone by shared with us by our members.

Do you have a special Mountain View memory to share? Then write to us at: info@mountainviewhistorical.org or mail us at: P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042.

History Happening Now

School Renaming Honors Amy Imai

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

The Mountain View Whisman school board voted in June to rename Huff Elementary School after Amy Imai, a Japanese American woman with strong ties to Mountain View. Trustees decided to rename the school after it was learned that Frank L. Huff held beliefs that are not compatible with that of inclusion and diversity. A year of searching for possible name options determined that Amy Imai was a good selection.

Imai, who was born in 1930, grew up in Mountain View. Her family was relocated during World War II to the Heart Mountain Detention Center in Wyoming. When the war was over the family returned to live in the area. She graduated from Fremont High School and was asked to speak at the graduation ceremony.

In 1957, Amy married Robert Imai and had four children. She and her husband built a successful business growing carnations. At her passing in 2013 she had five grandchildren. It was her involvement in the local community that made her the obvious choice in the renaming effort. Imai was an active supporter of the Mountain View–Los Altos Union High School District. She frequently spoke to students about her experiences during the Japanese internment. The Mountain View Buddhist Temple was a focus of her many talents. She was a Dharma school teacher for 45 years, coordinated the *otoki* (refreshments) for 15 years, and was an advocate for senior needs and recreation.



Amy Imai

As a Buddhist Amy believed that "you live each day, good or bad, and you make the best of it." She hoped to "make a difference in my passing through this life." With the renaming of the school, her legacy will be assured.

Spring 2021 Event Recap

Rengstorff house—30 years of Beauty: transformed!
A wonderfully researched presentation about Rengstorff House was featured at the May 2 general meeting. Martha Wallace, secretary of Friends of "R" House, gave a fact-filled and interesting talk. Many images of life during the time that Henry Rengstorff immigrated and then prospered in northern Santa Clara County and Mountain View were presented to an interested group of listeners. The City of Mountain View is celebrating the 30 years since the house was restored and opened to the public for viewing and use as a public space.

The beautiful Victorian Italianate home Rengstorff had built is considered to be one of the finest examples of this style of architecture on the West Coast. Martha detailed the life of Henry Rengstorff and his family's ownership of the house. Kristina Perino, senior recreation coordinator with the City, gave a long and twisting story of ownership, abandonment, and eventual restoration of this vital asset in Mountain View. Information was also given about the formation of Shoreline Park and the moving of Rengstorff House to its present location.

Following the formal presentation, a Q & A session followed. Ginny Kaminski, member at large of Friends of "R" House, and Mark Rogge, formerly of the city staff, gave additional thoughts and insight about the history and restoration of the house. The meeting can be viewed on YouTube- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jWB__WVWTd8&t=726s.



Rengstorff House in 1990 during restoration.

A big thanks to the contributing participants. The meeting was truly an inspiring story of the perseverance of our community to save the Rengstorff House.

Membership Report

Membership as of July 1, 2021

Honored Members	1
Life Members	107
Family Members	74
Single Members	75
TOTAL MEMBERSHIP	**257**

Membership as of July 1, 2021

A warm welcome to our new members, Michael Kahan and Tom Anderson!



A mid-1960s summer scene at the Rengstorff Park swimming pool.

Summertime and the membership renewal is easy!

Our membership chair, IdaRose Sylvester, is updating our membership database and needs your help. Many of our members haven't paid dues in a while, and some of our mailings are coming back "return to sender." We'll be sending out postcards and emails to people we are trying to reach within a few weeks, and you'll get contacted if we need help updating your information.

Do you have friends who were members? Without in-person meetings, it's easy to lose touch with each other. Can you help reach members you know, reminding them to look out for a message from us, and ask them to make sure they are up to date with us? We truly appreciate your help.

Have questions about your renewal status? Wish to upgrade to a lifetime or family membership? Drop IdaRose a line at idarose@mountainviewhistorical.org.

You can renew online at www.mountainviewhistorical.org or mail your renewal by using the form below. Thank you for your support!

MEMBERSHIP FORM

The MVHA welcomes new members! By becoming a member, you are making a special investment in our mission to preserve and share Mountain View history with the community, conserve priceless archival materials at the History Center, and hold memorable public events throughout the year. You can also join and renew online at **www.mountainviewhistorical.org**. Please support the MVHA, and join us today!

☐ New Membership

☐ Membership Renewal

☐ Single Membership: *$15/year*

☐ Family Membership: *$25/year*

☐ Life Membership: *$200*

Name(s): _____

Street Address: _____

City: _____

State: _____ Zip Code: _____

Telephone: _____

Email: _____

☐ *I'm interested in volunteer opportunities*

☐ *I'd like a print-edition subscription of the newsletter. (To save paper and costs, the default subscription is a digital emailed newsletter.)*

Please make checks payable to:
Mtn. View Historical Association

Mail this form to:
Mountain View Historical Association
c/o IdaRose Sylvester
P.O. Box 252
Mtn. View, CA 94042

Thank you!

SUMMER/AUTUMN

August 1
Sunday, 3:00 p.m. to 5:00 p.m.
MVHA Summer Event & Meeting
In-person at Rengstorff Park
See front page for more information!

September 15
Wednesday, 5:30 p.m. to 7:30 p.m.
MVHA Summer/Fall Board Meeting
Virtual Zoom meeting
All interested members welcome to attend! Email info@mountainviewhistorical.org for login.

September 18
Saturday, 9:00 a.m. to 12:00 p.m.
Mtn. View Harvest History Festival
Heritage Park, 771 N. Renstorff Avenue
More information on page 3.

November 7
Sunday, 1:00 p.m. to 3:00 p.m.
MVHA Fall Event & Meeting
Location TBD
More information in our next newsletter!

Looking Back: Photos from the Archive



In 1911, Crisanto Castro built the Villa Francisca, a large Mission-style home named in honor of his late wife. The Villa was located in the heart of what remained of the family's 8,800-acre Mexican-era land grant, Rancho Pastoria de las Borregas. In 1958, Cristanto's daugher Mercedes sold the Villa and the surrounding 23.5 acres of land—the last vesitage of the once vast rancho—to the City of Mountain View. Her hope was that the land would become a park and the Villa would become a history museum or senior center. In 1961, a suspicious fire damaged the first floor of the Villa's west wing. Rather than repair the damage, the City quickly demolished the entire building. Meanwhile, the surrounding 25 acres were transformed into a park. The City contemplated naming the park in honor of the Castros, but were convinced by councilman Harry True to name it "Mountain View Recreation Center Park." In 1970, it was renamed Rengstorff Park due to its location on Rengstorff Avenue. The park's group picnic area (the location of our next event, see page 1) was the location of the Villa Francisca.

EST. 1954

MOUNTAIN REVIEW

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